

To be is to be perceived



Anglo-Irish philosopher George Berkeley took the arguments put forward by Locke to extremes, proposing a theory of ‘immaterialism’ – that material substance does not exist. Locke established that all we can directly apprehend is the content of our own consciousness; Berkeley argued this means we can only have *indirect* sensory experience of things. And where Locke described objective, measurable ‘primary qualities’ of things we experience, and subjective ‘secondary qualities’, Berkeley pointed out that we do not actually experience things at all, *only* their qualities. Because we perceive ideas, not things in themselves, we have no grounds for believing

anything exists other than ideas and the minds that perceive them: things only exist if they either perceive or are perceived. Material substance, therefore, does not exist, and Berkeley, a Christian bishop, explained reality as existing in the mind of God. The classic example of his idea that 'to be is to be perceived' is a tree falling in a forest: does it make a sound if there is nobody there to hear it?